Q+A

"I WANT TO LISTEN BETTER"

Given the number of books he sells, author **CHETAN BHAGAT** does seem to have understood what Indian youngsters want from their literature. He now hopes his podcast will tell him what they want from life

Q. *Deeptalk with Chetan Bhagat*, your new Audible podcast, will see you interview everyone from CEOs and sportspeople to actors and experts. What made you want to play host?

I believe in lifelong learning and wanted to learn from some of the achievers in modern India today. Also, I wanted to listen better. No better way to do that than to interview people.

Q. For young India, your books and audiobooks provide much entertainment and inspiration. How much of an impact do you feel the nascent podcast format will have?

I think podcasts are going to be part of the future. Already, they are popular abroad and even in India. People will always need entertainment and inspiration, but the medium and format will keep changing. I hope to be able to contribute to this exciting space.

Q. You often use your social media to motivate your followers. What do you think is holding them back—fear or laziness?

Both. I think all of us have dreams in life and achieving them requires courage and discipline, which we lack from time to time. It is here that a motivational speaker can add value, by simply reminding you of the need to stay focused, not have fear and not give into laziness. It's a simple advice; implementing it is the hard part.

Q. As a popular newspaper columnist, you weigh in on several crucial matters, both social and political. Does that kind of regular engagement ever distract from your writing of fiction?

I try to use my columns to improve things in India as well, by giving solutions and suggestions to pressing problems. The regular columns help me stay in touch with what is happening in India, which I can then incorporate in my stories. In that sense, writing columns helps me. However, if I do too much of that, it will become distracting. Hence, I only do a short column every two weeks or so.

–with Shreevatsa Nevatia

